

As the British rose to power in India, the administration realized the need to reform the transportation system. Even though Warren Hastings, the first Governor-General of India (1774–85), undertook some road construction projects towards the end of his term in 1785, it was really during Lord William Bentinck's term (1828–35) that the administration spared serious thought over transportation and communication systems. Up to 48,280 km of roads were constructed but they failed to provide a sufficient network for the country. Even as late as 1856, when the railway had just sprung up on Indian soil, journeys remained long and tiresome.

Bengali philosopher, Debendranath Tagore, in his autobiography *Atmajivani* (1898) writes about his arduous travel from Calcutta in the east to Simla in the north in the same year. He travelled via boat from Calcutta for more than a month to reach Benaras, from where he proceeded on a coach to Allahabad. It took him 14 days to reach Agra and another month in a boat to get to Delhi. From Delhi, he travelled by coach till Ambala and then finally in a *jhampan*, a kind of palanquin, to reach Simla. Moreover, the roads were marred with thugs and murderers. British soldier and administrator William Henry Sleeman wrote, "the *thugs* reigned the highways and under the guise of friendship, win the confidence of unsuspecting travellers and merchants and after accompanying them for a stage or two, on reaching the first selected and retired spot, murder them and plunder their property". However, it was not the problems of the common travellers that precipitated the introduction of railways in the country.

Colonialism and its web

The birth of the railways in India was primarily centred around the social and political system of colonialism, which operated primarily on two grounds: military – for expansion and consolidation, and economic – for accruing financial gains. German philosopher Karl Marx spoke about the annihilation of the Old Asiatic Society and laying the material foundation of Western society in Asia, including railways, in "The Future Results of British Rule in India" (1853). The military importance of railways can be ascertained when Marx said, "Railways will afford the